



POISONED WATERS

Accidental oil spills from shipwrecked tankers or damaged offshore oil rigs poison sea life, and cover beaches with pollution. Industrial waste is also illegally dumped in the oceans, and this can contain equally dangerous substances that kill fish and other animals.



▲ OIL SPILL

Oil from the giant Norwegian tanker Mega Borg spills out into the Gulf of Mexico as fire crews put out the resulting fire.



▲ MANGROVE DESTRUCTION

Felling coastal mangrove forests to make way for tourist resorts destroys the natural habitats of animals, and exposes the shore to the full fury of tropical storms.

COASTAL DEVELOPMENT

The world's seashores are magnets for tourists, and the money to be earned from them has led to intense development of coastal regions. Many wild habitats, such as this mangrove forest, have been destroyed to make way for beach resorts. Coastal development can also lead to increased amounts of pollution, such as sewage and garbage that end up poisoning the sea and smothering nearby seagrass beds and coral reefs.

DEAD ZONES

Some big rivers are so contaminated with industrial chemicals and farm pesticides that they have poisoned the seabed where they flow into the sea. The most notorious of these dead zones covers more than 8,500 sq miles (22,000 sq km) of the Gulf of Mexico near the Mississippi River.



▲ TOXIC FLOW

This view from space shows mud and pollution spilling into the Gulf of Mexico from the Mississippi River.